NETI PRELIMS REVISION SERIES

Topic 03 | Species in News

नेति नेति — Less noise. More clarity.

Why this matters for Prelims: Species in News appear every single year in Prelims — as statement-based questions, matching pairs (species ↔ IUCN status / habitat), and single factual questions. UPSC tests: IUCN Red List category, habitat and range, legal protection status (WPA Schedule), CITES Appendix, and unique biological features. For newly discovered species, it tests the location of discovery.

> **Quick recall trick:** Four anchors for every species: (1) IUCN status, (2) habitat / range in India, (3) WPA Schedule (I = highest protection), (4) CITES Appendix (I = trade banned). Any species missing one of these anchors in your notes is a weak link UPSC will exploit.

IUCN RED LIST — CATEGORY QUICK REFERENCE

Category	Code	Meaning	Indian Examples
Extinct	EX	No known living individuals	Pink-headed Duck, Cheetah (Asiatic, 1952)
Extinct in Wild	EW	Survives only in captivity / cultivation	Gurney's Pitta (historical)
Critically Endangered	CR	Extremely high extinction risk	Great Indian Bustard, Gharial, White-rumped Vulture, Indian Pangolin, Pygmy Hog
Endangered	EN	High extinction risk	Bengal Tiger, Asiatic Lion, Gangetic Dolphin, Snow Leopard, Red Panda, Hoolock Gibbon
Vulnerable	VU	Moderate extinction risk	One-horned Rhino, Dugong, Gaur, Dhole, Sloth Bear
Near Threatened	NT	Close to qualifying as VU	Indian Leopard, Black-necked Crane, Fishing Cat (now EN)
Least Concern	LC	Low risk; widespread	Saltwater Crocodile, Common Leopard Cat, House Sparrow
Data Deficient	DD	Insufficient data to assess	Andaman Shrew, many deep-sea species

Note: IUCN Red List was established in 1964. It assesses species, NOT ecosystems or habitats. The Red Data Book is a different publication — published by respective national governments. Do not conflate the two.

CRITICALLY ENDANGERED SPECIES — INDIA (CR)

Species	Scientific Name	Habitat / Range	Key Exam Fact
Great Indian Bustard	Ardeotis nigriceps	Rajasthan (Desert NP), Gujarat, AP	State bird of Rajasthan; India's heaviest flying bird; <150 individuals; SC ordered underground power cables 2021; captive breeding at Desert NP, Jaisalmer
Gharial	Gavialis gangeticus	Chambal, Girwa, Gandak rivers	Longest snout of any crocodilian; National Chambal Sanctuary = largest wild population; Katerniaghat = second largest (2025 study)
Indian Pangolin	Manis crassicaudata	Pan-India, forested areas	CITES Appendix I; WPA Schedule I; most trafficked mammal globally; no teeth; scales are keratin
White-rumped Vulture	Gyps bengalensis	Indian subcontinent, SE Asia	99%+ population crash in 1990s; cause: diclofenac in cattle carcasses; ban on veterinary diclofenac: 2006; safe alternative: Meloxicam
Indian Vulture	Gyps indicus	Central & peninsular India	Also CR; same diclofenac cause; Vulture Safe Zones established; Jatayu Conservation Breeding Centre, Pinjore, Haryana
Slender-billed Vulture	Gyps tenuirostris	NE India, SE Asia	Third diclofenac-hit CR vulture; Red-headed Vulture (Sarcogyps calvus) also CR
Pygmy Hog	Porcula salvania	Manas NP, Assam	World's smallest wild pig; only wild population in Assam; Pygmy Hog Conservation Centre at Basistha, Guwahati
Forest Owlet	Heteroglaux blewitti	Central India (MP, Maharashtra)	Rediscovered in 1997 after 113 years; indicator of old-growth forest health

ENDANGERED SPECIES — INDIA (EN)

Species	Habitat / Key Location	WPA Schedule	Exam Distinguisher
Bengal Tiger (Panthera tigris tigris)	Pan-India; Project Tiger (1973); 3,682 tigers (2022 census)	I	National animal; 53 Tiger Reserves; TR with most tigers: Corbett; Project Tiger under NTCA
Asiatic Lion (Panthera leo persica)	Gir Forest NP, Gujarat only	I	891 individuals (2025 census); only wild Asiatic lion population outside Africa; proposal to shift some to Kuno NP (MP) opposed by Gujarat
Gangetic River Dolphin (Platanista gangetica)	Ganga-Brahmaputra-Meghna system	I	National aquatic animal; echolocation; indicator species for river health; Project Dolphin (2020)
Snow Leopard (Panthera uncia)	Himalayan & trans-Himalayan range: Ladakh, HP, Uttarakhand	I	~700 in India; prey: blue sheep (bharal) & Himalayan tahr; SECURE programme (GoI)
Red Panda (Ailurus fulgens)	Eastern Himalayas: Sikkim, Arunachal, W. Bengal	I	State animal of Sikkim; bamboo diet; NOT related to Giant Panda (different family: Ailuridae)
Hoolock Gibbon (Hoolock hoolock)	NE India — Assam, Arunachal, Meghalaya	I	India's only ape; arboreal; found in Namdapha TR (along with all 4 big cat species)
Sangai (Rucervus eldii eldii)	Keibul Lamjao NP, Manipur — only floating grass mat (phumdis)	I	State animal of Manipur; brow-antlered deer; found ONLY in Loktak Lake; <260 individuals
Nilgiri Tahr (Nilgiritragus hylocrius)	Nilgiri Hills, Eravikulam NP, Tamil Nadu	I	State animal of Tamil Nadu; only wild goat in peninsular India; ~2,500–3,000 individuals

VULNERABLE & OTHER NOTABLE SPECIES (VU / NT)

Species	IUCN	Habitat / Range	Key Exam Fact
One-horned Rhinoceros (Rhinoceros unicornis)	VU	Kaziranga NP (70%+), Manas NP, Pobitora WS, Assam + Nepal	Poaching for horn; translocated to Manas NP; recent sightings in Kaziranga after floods
Dugong (Dugong dugon)	VU	Gulf of Mannar, Palk Bay, Gulf of Kutch, A&N Islands	India's only marine herbivorous mammal; feeds on seagrass; 'Sea Cow'; India's first Dugong Conservation Reserve: Palk Bay, TN (2022); functionally extinct in China

Species	IUCN	Habitat / Range	Key Exam Fact
Gaur / Indian Bison (Bos gaurus)	VU	Pan-India forests; Nagarhole, Bandipur, Manas	World's largest wild cattle species; NOT a buffalo; state animal of Goa & Chhattisgarh
Dhole / Asiatic Wild Dog (Cuon alpinus)	EN	Indian subcontinent; Nilgiris, Central India	Pack hunter; key predator in tiger habitats; indicator of prey base health
Fishing Cat (Prionailurus viverrinus)	EN	Wetlands: Sundarbans, Chilika, Coringa WS	State animal of West Bengal; swims; webbed feet; wetland indicator species
Irrawaddy Dolphin (Orcaella brevirostris)	EN	Sundarbans, Chilika Lake, Mahakam Lake (Indonesia)	Freshwater & coastal; Chilika Lake population significant; distinct from Gangetic dolphin
Amur Falcon (Falco amurensis)	LC	Breeds in E. Asia; winters via NE India (Nagaland) to Africa	Largest raptor migration through India; Nagaland (Doyang reservoir) = major stopover; conservation success story
Olive Ridley Turtle (Lepidochelys olivacea)	VU	Gahirmatha, Rushikulya, Devi (Odisha) — mass nesting (Arribada)	One of five sea turtle species in India; Gahirmatha = world's largest rookery; WPA Schedule I; CITES Appendix I

BIRDS — SPECIAL FOCUS

Bird	IUCN / WPA	Habitat	Key Distinguisher
Great Indian Bustard	CR / Sch. I	Arid grasslands — Rajasthan, Gujarat	Heaviest flying bird in India; <150 left; power lines = #1 threat; state bird of Rajasthan
Bengal Florican (Houbaropsis bengalensis)	CR / Sch. I	Tall grasslands: Assam, UP (Dudhwa), Cambodia	Critically endangered; grassland loss from agriculture; display flights at dawn
Lesser Florican (Sypheotides indicus)	EN / Sch. I	Seasonal grasslands: Rajasthan, Gujarat, MP	Only florican species endemic to India; monsoon breeding; sky-dancing display
Black-necked Crane (Grus nigricollis)	VU / Sch. I	Ladakh — Changthang plateau; Arunachal	High-altitude crane; winters in Bhutan & Arunachal; sacred in Buddhist culture
Sarus Crane (Antigone antigone)	VU / Sch. IV	UP, Rajasthan wetlands	World's tallest flying bird; state bird of Uttar Pradesh; monogamous; non-migratory in India
Red-headed Vulture (Sarcogyps calvus)	CR / Sch. I	Pan-India, SE Asia	Also called Asian King Vulture; CR; diclofenac victim; monotypic genus

Bird	IUCN / WPA	Habitat	Key Distinguisher
Kaiser-i-Hind (Teinopalpus imperialis)	VU / Sch. I	Eastern Himalayas: Arunachal, Sikkim, Nagaland	State butterfly of Arunachal Pradesh; swallowtail family; high-altitude forests
Amur Falcon (Falco amurensis)	LC	Passes through Nagaland (Doyang reservoir)	Longest migration of any falcon; poaching converted to protection in Nagaland — model conservation

REPTILES, AMPHIBIANS & AQUATIC SPECIES

Species	IUCN / WPA	Key Location	Exam Fact
Gharial (Gavialis gangeticus)	CR / Sch. I	National Chambal Sanctuary (MP-UP-Raj); Katerniaghat WS (UP)	Only member of family Gavialidae; long narrow snout for fish; male has ghara (nasal excrescence) at tip
Mugger Crocodile (Crocodylus palustris)	VU / Sch. I	Freshwater: Chambal, Mahanadi, Bhitarkanika	Broad snout; most widespread crocodilian in India; freshwater; nesting in sandbars
Saltwater Crocodile (Crocodylus porosus)	LC / Sch. I	Bhitarkanika (Odisha), A&N Islands, Sundarbans	World's largest living reptile; NT in India; migratory; estuarine & coastal
Olive Ridley Turtle	VU / Sch. I	Gahirmatha, Rushikulya, Devi beaches, Odisha	Arribada (mass nesting); Gahirmatha = world's largest rookery; CITES Appendix I
Leatherback Sea Turtle (Dermochelys coriacea)	VU / Sch. I	A&N Islands — Great Nicobar (primary nesting)	World's largest turtle; no bony shell — leathery skin; Great Nicobar dev project controversy
King Cobra (Ophiophagus hannah)	VU / Sch. II	Western Ghats, NE India	World's longest venomous snake; feeds only on other snakes; unique nest-builder
Limnonectes motijheel (Fanged Frog)	Not Assessed	Namdapha TR, Arunachal Pradesh	New species discovered April 2026; named after Motijheel Lake; genus Limnonectes; 6th known in India
Myristica Swamp Tree Frog (Mercurana myristicapalustris)	EN	Kerala — Myristica swamps (relic ecosystem)	Found only in Myristica freshwater swamps; functionally relict habitat; high endemism

PLANTS & FLORA IN NEWS

Species / Plant	Status	Location	Why Exam-Relevant
Red Sanders (Pterocarpus santalinus)	EN (IUCN) / Sch. I (WPA)	Tirumala Hills, Andhra Pradesh (endemic)	Highly trafficked; CITES Appendix II; used in traditional medicine & musical instruments; protected under WPA & CITES
Saussurea obvallata (Brahma Kamal)	Not threatened	Uttarakhand Himalayas (above 4,500 m)	State flower of Uttarakhand; blooms in Himalayan alpine zone; religious significance; protected by WPA
Neelakurinji (Strobilanthes kunthiana)	LC	Nilgiri Hills (Shola grasslands)	Blooms once every 12 years; last bloom 2018; next 2030; state flower of Kerala (contested); gives Nilgiris ('blue mountains') their name
Blue Vanda (Vanda coerulea)	EN	Namdapha NP, Arunachal Pradesh; NE India	Rare orchid; blue-coloured; found in Namdapha; CITES Appendix I
Ophiorrhiza gajureliana	Not Assessed	Mayodia Forest, Arunachal Pradesh	Newly identified plant species (late 2024); highlights botanical richness of NE India
Mishimi Teeta (Coptis teeta)	VU (IUCN)	Arunachal Pradesh — Mishmi Hills	Medicinal plant used by local tribes; alkaloid berberine; over-harvested; in Namdapha area
Cycas beddomei	CR (IUCN)	Andhra Pradesh — Eastern Ghats	Critically endangered cycad; CITES Appendix I; relies on specific pollinators; ancient plant lineage (gymnosperm)

RECENTLY DISCOVERED SPECIES — 2024–2026

Species	Type	Location of Discovery	Significance
Limnonectes motijheel	Amphibian (Fanged Frog)	Namdapha Tiger Reserve, Arunachal Pradesh (2026)	6th Limnonectes species in India; named after Motijheel Lake; males have fang-like jaw projections
Ophiorrhiza gajureliana	Plant (Rubiaceae family)	Mayodia Forest, Arunachal Pradesh (2024)	New species from NE India biodiversity hotspot; highlights under-surveyed forests
Tenkana jayamangali	Jumping Spider (Arachnida)	Southern India (2024)	New genus + species of jumping spider; arachnological diversity of peninsular India

Species	Type	Location of Discovery	Significance
Tapanuli Orangutan (Pongo tapanuliensis)	Mammal	Tapanuli, Sumatra, Indonesia (formally described 2017)	World's rarest great ape; < 800 individuals; critically endangered; separate from Sumatran & Bornean orangutans
Akarotaxis gouldae (Banded Dragonfish)	Fish	Southern Ocean, near Antarctica (2024)	Deep-sea fish; bioluminescent; unique banded pattern; extreme cold-water adaptation
Trithemis palustres	Dragonfly	Philippines (rediscovered 2024)	Previously unknown; noteworthy for unique coloration and habitat specificity

CONSERVATION PROGRAMS — SPECIES-SPECIFIC

Program	Target Species	Year Launched	Key Detail
Project Tiger	Bengal Tiger	1973 (Indira Gandhi)	53 Tiger Reserves; administered by NTCA (National Tiger Conservation Authority); latest count: 3,682 (2022 census)
Project Elephant	Asian Elephant	1992	29 Elephant Reserves; corridor protection; human-elephant conflict mitigation; State Animal of several states
Project Dolphin	Gangetic & Irrawaddy Dolphin	2020 (PM Modi)	National aquatic animal (Gangetic Dolphin since 2009); river health indicator; targets Ganga & Chilika
Project Cheetah	African Cheetah	Sep 2022	World's first intercontinental carnivore reintroduction; 8 from Namibia (Sep 2022) + 12 from South Africa (Feb 2023); location: Kuno NP, MP; Asiatic cheetah extinct in India since 1952
Sea Turtle Conservation	Olive Ridley, Leatherback	Ongoing — MoEFCC	Operation Olivia (Odisha); Gahirmatha Marine Sanctuary; nest relocation programmes
Vulture Safe Zones	Gyps vultures (3 CR spp.)	Post-2006	Diclofenac-free buffer zones around vulture breeding colonies; Jatayu Conservation Breeding Centre, Pinjore
Dugong Conservation Reserve	Dugong	2022 (Palk Bay, TN)	India's first; protects seagrass beds; addresses bycatch in fishing nets

Program	Target Species	Year Launched	Key Detail
MISHTI Mission	Mangrove Habitats	Union Budget 2023-24	Mangrove Initiative for Shoreline Habitats & Tangible Incomes; Sundarbans & coastal states; not species-specific but habitat-critical

⚖ LEGAL PROTECTION — WPA SCHEDULES & CITES

Framework	Schedule / Appendix	Protection Level	Key Species Examples
Wildlife Protection Act 1972 (India)	Schedule I	Absolute protection; highest penalty	Tiger, Lion, Elephant, Gharial, Gangetic Dolphin, GIB, Pangolin, All Vultures, Olive Ridley, Red Sanders
Wildlife Protection Act 1972 (India)	Schedule II	High protection; hunting banned	King Cobra, Hyena, Porcupine, Jackal, Peafowl (National Bird)
Wildlife Protection Act 1972 (India)	Schedule III & IV	Protected but lower penalty	Sarus Crane (Sch. IV), Hog Deer, Nilgai
CITES (Convention on International Trade in Endangered Species)	Appendix I	Commercial trade prohibited	Tiger, Elephant, Pangolin, Gharial, Leatherback Turtle, Olive Ridley, Red Sanders, Blue Vanda
CITES	Appendix II	Trade allowed with permits; monitored	Sloth Bear, Gaur, Saltwater Crocodile, Seahorse, Red Coral
CITES	Appendix III	Protection in at least one country; cooperation needed	Walrus (Canada), Honey Badger (Botswana)

Note: WPA 1972 has been amended multiple times. The 2022 amendment added provisions for invasive alien species and re-categorised some species. CITES is NOT a domestic law — it governs international trade. WPA governs domestic hunting and possession.

★ **PYQ Insight:** UPSC has asked species questions in almost every paper (2013, 2015, 2017, 2019, 2022, 2024). Recurring traps: (1) Gharial is CR, not Mugger — Mugger is VU; Saltwater is LC. UPSC asked to identify the gharial by its habitat in 2014. (2) Snow Leopard is EN, not VU or CR — commonly confused. (3) Sarus Crane is VU and world's tallest flying bird — but GIB is India's heaviest flying bird. Both tested in same year. (4) Red Panda is EN and family Ailuridae — NOT related to Giant Panda (Ursidae). (5) Project Cheetah introduced African cheetah, not Asiatic — subspecies distinction is testable. Statement I/II: 'The Sangai deer is found in Keibul Lamjao NP — Statement II: Keibul Lamjao NP is the only floating national park in the world.' Both correct, and II correctly explains why it is a unique habitat for Sangai. This exact pattern has been framed in mocks and is ripe for 2026 Prelims.

3 THINGS UPSC TESTS FROM THIS TOPIC

- **IUCN Status + Correct Category —** The most frequent error: students confuse CR / EN / VU. Build a 3-column table in memory: CR = GIB, Gharial, Pangolin, Vultures, Pygmy Hog. EN = Tiger, Lion, Dolphin, Snow Leopard, Red Panda. VU = Rhino, Dugong, Olive Ridley.
- **Habitat + Location Precision —** Not just 'forests' — which forest, which state, which water body. Sangai = Loktak Lake (Manipur) only. Gharial = Chambal (not Ganga). Dugong = Gulf of Mannar (not Bay of Bengal). Leatherback = Great Nicobar (not Odisha).
- **Conservation Program + Legal Status —** Which Schedule of WPA, which CITES Appendix, which conservation mission, and since when. Project Tiger (1973) vs Project Elephant (1992) vs Project Dolphin (2020) vs Project Cheetah (2022) — years are tested. Diclofenac ban year (2006) and safe alternative (Meloxicam) are classic UPSC-style specifics.

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